Someone made haste to arrest me. All that, later, they gave as reason was that Sasikumaran had ‘confessed’ that I was hand in glove with him in carting away drawings from ISRO. The CBI report, endorsed by the Chief Judicial Magistrate, Ernakulam, and later the Supreme Court, said no such thing happened. Before all, that if they did suspect that I had traded drawings for dollars, they should have raided my house and office. They did not.

Had they raided my place, as the CBI did later, they would have nothing to substantiate their claims with, and my arrest would not have made sense. So, I had to be implicated even without evidence. Someone wanted the head of the cryogenic mission arrested as part of the plot. The project had be stalled.

Curiously enough, I was arrested on 30 November 1994, the same day the Kerala Police wrote to hand over the investigation to the CBI. Once you have decided to entrust the central agency with the investigation, why not wait for them to take a decision on my arrest? From the beginning, Dhar and his colleague Ratan Sehgal were in a tearing hurry to establish espionage even though there was no evidence. Dhar’s book mentions about Ratan Sehgal in the initial phase of the investigation, but Dhar took upon himself the task of being the prime fabricator of the ISRO spy case.

The timing of the implication of ISRO makes it a suspect on at least two counts. One, when Dhar came to Trivandrum, the countdown for the launch of PSLV-D2 rocket was about to begin. Even as he was questioning Mariam Rasheeda and Fauziyya Hassan, on 15 October 1994, PSLV-D2 put in orbit Indian Remote Sensing Satellite IRS-P2. It was the first successful launch of an Indian rocket that could be used for commercial satellite launches. Two, ISRO was in the process of bringing materials and drawings as part of a cryogenic technology transfer from Russia after the US imposed sanctions on Russia and India. Owing to the pressure from the US, Glavkosmos wanted to cancel the contract, but ISRO had succeeded in advancing some milestones and making payments before the new clauses kicked in.

It was quite an achievement for us to have skirted the US pressure to bring home the cryogenic consignments. We managed, much to the chagrin